

HEALTH LITERACY LESSON

Safe Drinking Water at Home

Unsafe water is one of the most common causes of preventable illness, especially for children. A few simple habits can make a real difference.

Signs water may be unsafe

- Cloudy or unusually discolored appearance
- An unusual smell or taste
- Coming from a source known to be contaminated, such as an open well near a latrine, floodwater, or a stagnant pond

Ways to make water safer at home

- **Boiling** — bring water to a full, rolling boil for at least 1 minute. This kills most disease-causing germs.
- **Filtering** — a clean cloth folded several times can remove some sediment, though it does not remove germs. A proper water filter is more effective when available.
- **Solar disinfection** — in an emergency, filling a clear plastic bottle with water and leaving it in direct, strong sunlight for at least 6 hours can help disinfect it.

Storing water safely

Keep treated water in a clean, covered container. A container with a narrow opening or a tap helps prevent hands or dirty cups from touching the water directly.

Basic sanitation habits

Keep drinking water sources away from latrines, animal waste, and garbage, and wash storage containers regularly.

This lesson is for general education and does not replace advice from a qualified health professional. If you are concerned about a symptom, please seek medical care.

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